



No iTunes for you

That's what Apple's new update to its iTunes software, is saying to Palm Pre. The update cuts off devices that pretend to be iPhones



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Cellphones can predict floods

As outrageous as the above headline sounds, it seems to be true. At least according to the research scientists at Tel Aviv University who published their findings in an issue of Atmospheric Chemistry and Physics journal. "By monitoring the specific and fluctuating atmospheric moisture around cell phone towers throughout America, we can cheaply, effectively and reliably provide a more accurate 'critical moisture distribution' level for fine-tuning model predictions of big floods," says Prof. Pinhas Alpert, a geophysicist and head of Tel Aviv University's Porter School for Environmental Education.

That means that they can predict the intensity of the flood too. The premise is based on the fact that signal strength diminishes due to moisture present in the atmosphere. Combining this with rainfall distribution data, scientists were able to predict flash floods that happen frequently in the Judean Desert in Israel. With this new piece of information provided by cell phone towers, the world's weather bureaus that are usually under a lot of flack for poor predictive ability, will have an edge. Since cell phone towers are available in plenty all over most regions, implementing this system should also be quite simple. Considering the amount of mayhem caused by floods in Mumbai, the city should be the first candidate for installing such a system.

Mobile users concerned about security

In our last issue we reported that the rapid growth of smart phones, with mobile applications that connect to the web, has set the stage for mobile viruses to disrupt things in this sphere. Now we hear of two new reports that are indicative of an impending crisis in this arena. The first is a finding by US-based Cloudmark Inc., which states that "nearly two thirds of mobile device owners are concerned about the security of their devices." This report is based on a survey of 1,812 U.S. adults. The survey also found that such concerns are restraining users from opting for new mobile services for financial transactions and shopping. This is interesting from the point of view of the revenue loss to the industry at large as a result of on-the-go users not feeling secure enough to transact from their mobile phones.

The other report is of Trend Micro announcing that it has spotted the first mobile botnet. Botnets have till now only been seen in the PC world. According to TrendMicro's Research Lab, the Symbian-based malware, labelled SYMBOS_YXES.B, could be downloaded from malicious mobile sites by unsuspecting users. "A Symbian Information Source file collects



phone and subscriber ID and network information on affected devices, and connects to a web site in order to send the information on. In addition, it can also send spammed SMS to the user's contacts acquired from the web site it connected to earlier", states Trend Micro Labs. In short, it appears to be a botnet for mobile phones. It will be interesting to see what the future holds for the open source mobile OS Android, in terms of malicious attacks like these.

Google Voice now truly mobile

Google Voice, the invitation only service launched by Google a while ago has now been ported to Android and Blackberry. The service

basically lets you have one "Google Voice" number which is connected to your other numbers such as your office, home and mobile number. You can choose which of the phones you want ringing when someone calls. One of the features it boasts is caller groups, with restricted access to certain phones. For instance, friends can have access to all three numbers while your pesky neighbour can be allowed to bug you only when you are at home. The best part is that people only have to remember a single number. The number stays with you for life, so even if you change your other numbers it doesn't make a difference. Simply update the new numbers with the service.

Google Voice also gives you other services such as voice mail and automated transcripts of the same.

With the newly released Google Voice mobile app for Blackberry and Android, placing outgoing calls from a Google Voice number has become easier, said a blog post from Google. The app is fully integrated with contacts on the phone. For the thousands of people who don't have an Android or Blackberry device, Google has a mobile web version which can be accessed by typing www.google.com/voice into your mobile phone's browser. The blog post also says that "currently, Google Voice is only available in the US". Let's hope it comes to our shores soon.



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